Grace Shih

SENIOR STAFF UI/UX DESIGNER

LinkedIn Profile

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Rockville, MD

Experienced and strategic UI/UX Design Leader with over 20 years of driving impactful digital experiences across diverse industries. Proven expertise in leading end-to-end design initiatives – from user research and design systems to accessibility compliance and cross-functional collaboration. Adept at aligning design vision with business goals, mentoring creative teams, and delivering scalable, user-centered solutions that enhance usability, engagement, and performance. Strong track record of managing complex projects, guiding creative direction, and building high-performing design teams in fast-paced, agile environments.

EXPERIENCE

Senior Staff UX/UI Designer, UXC, CUA, CPACC, DHS Trusted Tester for Web

Essex Management, Contractor to National Cancer Institute, Rockville, MD
July 2019 – Present

- Led the planning, creation, and implementation of a centralized Design System and Guidelines for all Precision Medicine Analysis and Coordination Center (PMACC) applications, standardizing UI/UX across multiple platforms.
- Directed the UI/UX team in identifying and resolving usability and accessibility issues across existing PMACC apps, driving consistent UX enhancements.
- Defined design strategy for new high-impact applications, including the COVID-19 Seroprevalence Study Hub and Clinical Sample Management System.
- Collaborated on business requirements, conducted information architecture planning, and delivered fully interactive prototypes for stakeholder alignment and approval.
- Led UX research and design workshops, facilitating user requirement gathering, ideation, and consensus across multi-disciplinary teams.
- Produced critical UX deliverables such as user journey maps, user stories, personas, and site maps to inform and guide design decisions.
- Actively participated in Agile sprints, providing detailed design mockups and interactive prototypes to support efficient development.
- Championed accessibility best practices, delivering ongoing training to developers, conducting audits, and creating VPATs with actionable remediation plans.

Creative Director, CUA

American Institutes for Research, Washington, D.C.
February 2012 – July 2019

- Led and mentored a design team of 15+ designers, accessibility specialists, and technical writers to support over 30 projects annually and foster a significant increase in cross-functional collaboration efficiency.
- Established and implemented department-wide design systems, including style guides and pattern/icon libraries, resulting in a major reduction in design-to-development handoff time.

- Authored comprehensive accessibility guidelines and developed an accessible widget library, adopted across 100% of engineering teams, ensuring all new products met WCAG 2.0 AA compliance.
- Architected and standardized creative workflows, reducing project onboarding time and improving process transparency across the Assessment program.
- Directed UI/UX strategy for mission-critical assessment tools, enhancing usability for over one million students and users.
- Led WCAG 2.0 compliance and VPAT documentation efforts, securing third-party certifications that enabled continued partnership with major government and education clients.
- Redesigned AIR's Test Information Distribution Engine (TIDE), improving task efficiency and reducing user error rates through a re-architected interface based on real user stories.

Senior Web UI Designer/Application Developer

Pillsbury Winthrop Shaw Pittman LLP, Washington, D.C.
June 2000 – February 2012

- Designed and developed client extranets for secure document sharing, real-time status tracking.
- Collaborated with clients across diverse industries, including energy, financial services, real estate, and technology, to define software requirements and design intuitive user interfaces.
- Contributed to the marketing team's efforts in redesigning the company's award-winning website and developing its first SharePoint-powered intranet.

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

UX Certified
Nielson Norman Group (UXC)

Certified Usability Analyst
Human Factors International (CUA)

Accessibility Core Competencies (CPACC)
IAAP - International Association of Accessibility Professionals

DHS Trusted Tester for Web
U.S. Department of Homeland Security

Master of Science, Computer Science
University of North Virginia

Bachelor of Fine Arts in Electronic Imaging, Magna Cum Laude
Washington State University

KEY SKILLS

Design & UX Expertise
- Universal design
- Prototyping
- UX research & usability testing
- Web accessibility (WCAG compliance)

Tools & Technology
- Adobe Creative Cloud, Figma
- Design System (creation, scaling, governance)
- HTML/CSS/jQuery (working knowledge)
- Front-end frameworks (collaboration understanding)

Collaboration & Impact
- Leading design reviews
- Stakeholder communication
- Working in Agile/Scrum environment

Strategy & Leadership
- Design strategy & vision setting
- Mentoring & coaching designers
- Crossing-functioning collaboration
- DesignOps & process improvement